

B. ALLOCATION PACKAGE NARRATIVE EXPLANATION

- i. **An explanation of what funding and service actions are being taken within the region that utilize resources other than SB 125 funding.**

Madera County is located in California's San Joaquin Central Valley. Encompassing 2,147 square miles, the County is situated in the geographic center of the State of California along State Route (SR) 99, between the counties of Merced and Fresno. It is bounded on the northwest by the Chowchilla River, on the south and west by the San Joaquin River, and on the east by the crest of the Sierra Nevada mountain range. The Madera County region has three public transit systems operated by the County of Madera (Madera County Connection), the City of Madera (Madera Metro), and the City of Chowchilla (Chowchilla Area Transit Express). Intercity rail service in the region is provided by the San Joaquins Intercity Rail Service (San Joaquins), which is managed by the San Joaquin Joint Powers Authority (SJJPAA).

RAIL

The San Joaquins extends 364 miles and provides direct rail service to 11 counties: Sacramento, Contra Costa, Alameda, San Joaquin, Stanislaus, Merced, Madera, Fresno, Kings, Tulare, and Kern. Between Oakland and Bakersfield, the San Joaquins route is 315 miles long and has 13 intermediate stops. The San Joaquins have great potential for increased ridership, revenue, service coordination, and performance. SJJPAA is currently implementing a number of strategies to improve the San Joaquins. Some of the strategies require little or no additional resources, including improved schedules and reduced trip lengths, reduced travel times, improved train monitoring, train and connecting bus schedule adjustments, and improved service coordination. SJJPAA is also in the process of pursuing a significant expansion of service for the San Joaquins, including implementation of the 8th and 9th Daily Roundtrips. Planned expansion of the San Joaquins Service is fully coordinated and consistent with the 2018 California State Rail Plan and the California High Speed Rail Authority's (HSR) 2022 Business Plan. Safety continues to be a focus and SJJPAA is engaging in partnerships with Amtrak and the host railroads to reduce incidents along the corridor.

SJJPAA will be leveraging a substantial amount of funding from other sources in addition to SB 125 funding to aid the Madera County region. This will enable the completion of the Madera HSR Station (Phase 1 & 2) which is a high priority for the State and critical for the network integration between the San Joaquins and HSR Early Operating Segment.

For the Madera HSR Station Phase 1, the total cost is estimated at \$44.65 million. If approved, \$9 million through SB 125 funding will be used for the completion of Phase 1. The remaining \$35.65 million will be coming from Transit Intercity Rail Capital Program (TIRCP) funding already secured by SJPA. This project has also received TIRCP funding in 2018 and additional TIRCP funding in early 2023 as part of the special round for Existing TIRCP Projects.

For the Madera HSR Station Phase 2, the total cost is estimated at \$134 million. If approved, \$3 million of SB 125 funding will be used to initiate PS&E – final design. Phase 2 is expected to receive \$80 million from the 2024 Interregional Transportation Improvement Program (ITIP) that is scheduled to be approved by the California Transportation Commission in March 2024, and \$51 million from either State or Federal funding (Caltrans in partnership with SJPA applied for Multimodal Project Discretionary Grant – MEGA funding for Phase 2 to complete the funding, SJPA will apply for 2024 TIRCP funding and is also working with Caltrans to submit an application for Solutions for Congested Corridors Program funding in case the Federal funding is not received or less funding than is needed to complete the project is received.

The San Joaquins operational subsidy is paid for by the State's Public Transportation Account. The SJPA 2023 Business Plan shows \$69.5 million for FY 23/24 for just the Amtrak Contract, and \$71.2 million for FY 24/25. Operations and Maintenance costs are anticipated to continue to grow over time for the service. If approved, \$860,000 of SB 125 funds will go towards San Joaquins operational costs for enhanced security at the Relocated Madera San Joaquins Station (Phase 1) once operations begin in mid-2025. This funding is critical for ensuring increased ridership and revenue at the new, relocated station.

TRANSIT

Madera County Connection - Madera County operates a public transit service branded as Madera County Connection (MCC). MCC services are provided in a seventy-three square mile area within the county of Madera, in Central California on the State Route 99 and State Route 41 corridors between Fresno and Merced. MCC is categorized as a small transit agency and currently operates a fleet of thirteen in-service and spare buses and vans of varying sizes for local fixed-route and dial-a-ride services. MCC does not plan to use any SB 125 funding for operations during fiscal years 2024-2027.

Chowchilla Area Transit Express – The City of Chowchilla operates Chowchilla Area Transit Express (CATX), a public, demand-responsive service within the Chowchilla area. CATX is categorized as a small transit agency with a fleet of four vehicles. CATX does not plan to use any SB 125 funding for operations during fiscal years 2024-2027.

Madera Metro – The City of Madera operates the Madera Metro fixed route system and Madera Dial-a-Ride. The fixed route system primarily serves residents within the city limits, while utilizing dial-a-ride to serve a five-mile radius from the downtown area. Madera Metro is categorized as a small transit agency with a fleet of nineteen vehicles. Madera Metro does not plan to use any SB 125 funding for operations during fiscal years 2024-2027.

Public transit services in Madera County are supported by a variety of funding sources, including:

- Federal Transit Administration (FTA)
 - a. Sections 5311, 5339 and 5307 Funds
 - b. Bus and Bus Facilities grants
 - c. Coronavirus Aid, Relief, and Economic Security (CARES) Act
 - d. Coronavirus Response and Relief Supplemental Appropriations Act (CRRSA)
 - e. Infrastructure Investment and Jobs Act (IIJA)
- Congestion Mitigation and Air Quality (CMAQ) Program
- State Transportation Development Act Funds (TDA)
 - a. Local Transportation Funds (LTF)
 - b. State Transit Assistance (STA)
- SB-1 State of Good Repair (SGR)
- Low Carbon Transit Operations Program (LCTOP)
- Measure T – Local Sales Tax
- San Joaquin Valley Air Pollution Control District (SJVAPCD)
- Farebox Revenue

The Transit Operator Worksheets detail how each operator has obligated funds from each available funding source.

The transit operators in Madera County do not foresee any operational deficits through the 2025-26 fiscal year. The agencies can continue operations with other available funding sources besides SB 125. The Federal funding that has been received, particularly through the CARES Act and the CRRSA Act, helped the agencies to carry over existing funds and continue operations without reducing service. Madera County's Local ½ Percent Sales Tax (Measure T) is a revenue source that the transit agencies use as a match to leverage other funding and provides supplemental financial support. In the City of Madera, passenger fares were waived for the Fixed Route Service system, but passenger fares for the Dial-a-Ride System were re-introduced for most riders except for those with disabilities or seniors. To account for the lost revenue, the City used LCTOP funds. Across the region, strategies to increase ridership have been successful through marketing, improved service, and free rides. There are several capital projects planned over the next few years that will be completed with current available funding. In Madera County, projects that will assist the region in reducing greenhouse gas emissions and decrease adverse health effects related to travel rise in priority. From this perspective, the transit agencies have prioritized using SB 125 funding to transition their fleets to 100% zero-emission by 2040 in accordance with the Innovative Clean Transit (ICT) Regulation. Completing this transition results in significant air quality and health benefits for the region.

ii. **A description and justification of the RTPA strategy to use SB 125 funding to construct capital projects and fund operating expenses that lead to improved outcomes in its jurisdiction.**

The western half of the county is considered disadvantaged and low-income with the cities of Chowchilla and Madera and smaller communities, like La Vina and Fairmead, being exposed to high levels of pollution due to greenhouse gas emissions by vehicles, including buses. The western half of the county is where most of the transit-dependent population is located, therefore they are more likely to be exposed to emissions from traditional buses.

The California Air Resources Board's (CARB) ICT Regulation requires all public transit agencies in the State of California to transition from conventionally fueled buses to zero-emission buses by 2040. This regulation requires a progressive increase of an agency's new bus purchases to be zero-emission buses (ZEBs) based on their fleet size. By 2040, CARB expects all transit agencies in the State to be operating only ZEBs.

In harmony with the State's initiatives, there are regional strategies in place to positively affect air quality and mitigate the pollution burden in Madera County, particularly in disadvantaged areas. One strategy is to progressively replace the region's bus fleet with zero-emission buses by the target date of 2040. Another strategy is to shift people from using cars to travel on the highway to traveling instead by passenger rail or high-speed rail. Establishing extended commuter/intercity rail and high-speed rail service and connections will not only offset the impacts of congestion on SR 99, but will also reduce greenhouse gas emissions, and expand mobility options for the transit-dependent population.

Using SB 125 funding to support the local transit agencies' transition to a new zero-emission bus fleet is a sound approach for our region. Implementing a zero-emission bus fleet is expensive because the upfront costs are higher for the vehicles and the supporting infrastructure. The local transit agencies in Madera County are small and have limited resources to be successful when competing for other sources of funding. Utilizing the SB 125 funding provides a guaranteed funding source to accommodate the cost of transitioning their fleets by 2040.

A rail project of major significance in Madera County is the Madera High-Speed Rail Station Phase 1: Relocated Madera San Joaquin Station. The existing Madera San Joaquin Station is being relocated to a location near Avenue 12 to better meet regional goals of improving ridership and connectivity. Avenue 12 is a primary transit route for Madera County. Future plans include expanding local transit access to the new station. Schedules will be coordinated, providing additional routes and increased frequency. The station will enable Madera County to have direct access to high-speed rail service and better connect it with Fresno, the larger Central Valley region, and the rest of California. Future transit-oriented development along the Avenue 12 Corridor, which connects SR 99 and SR 41, together with improved transit connectivity, will ensure that Madera County, particularly its transit-dependent population, can capture the full economic and environmental benefits of high-speed rail and sustainable growth patterns. Prioritizing this project locally by allocating SB 125 funds toward its completion is a

logical approach because it is a boon to the region and is also synergetic with the State's direction to prioritize existing TIRCP projects.

- iii. **A detailed breakdown and justification for how the funding is proposed to be distributed between transit operators and among projects, consistent with the legislative intent described in SB 125.**

Madera HSR Station Phase 1: Relocated Madera San Joaquins Station – SJJPA plans to use a total of \$12,862,060 in SB 125 TIRCP funds for the Madera HSR Station Phase 1: Relocated Madera San Joaquins Station project. If approved, the funding will be allocated as follows:

- \$9 million for construction for Phase 1 (Relocated Madera San Joaquins Station)
- \$862,060 for Phase 1 Operations for additional security it the Relocated Station to ensure high ridership
- \$3 million for Phase 2 (Madera HSR Station for Early Operating Segment) towards PS&E (Final Design)

SJJPA worked with the Madera County Transportation Commission (MCTC), the City of Madera, and the County of Madera to find an improved location for a relocated Madera Station. The existing station has limited use, no transit connections, poor access to SR 99, and its location is expected to see only marginal growth in employment and transportation demand. A relocated Madera station is being implemented by SJJPA for a location just north of the new Avenue 12 grade separation. Avenue 12 is a primary transit corridor for Madera County. The relocated station north of Avenue 12 will be consistent with the growth of Madera east of the BNSF line; provides the opportunity for transit-oriented development in the station vicinity; and will be closer to Madera Community College. Phase 1 of the project will be operational (the relocated San Joaquins station) by 2025. The SB 125 funding will mitigate cost escalation and support the construction of improvements which would be utilized initially by the San Joaquins and then by HSR passengers once the future Madera High-Speed Rail Station begins operations. This funding will help to ensure the schedule is maintained to complete Phase 1 by mid-2025. Since the Madera Rail Station Relocation is an existing TIRCP project, having received TIRCP funding in 2018 and additional TIRCP funding in early 2023 as part of the special round for Existing TIRCP Projects, it is in harmony with the SB 125 program goals to prioritize this project. It is understood that TIRCP-funded capital projects that are already substantially funded and in need of additional resources for completion are expected to be prioritized over beginning new projects. This project is eligible for SB 125 funding and is strongly supported by the State.

County of Madera Transit Fleet Electrification – The County of Madera is requesting \$2,855,761 in TIRCP funding and \$699,239 in Zero Emission Transit Capital Program (ZETCP) funding for a total of \$3,555,000 to purchase five electric buses, sixteen electric bus chargers and for the installation of eight satellite charging stations. These funds will assist with the County's Transit Electrification project, funding the purchase and installation of additional battery-electric buses, vehicle chargers and related infrastructure. This will enable the County to complete Federal and State requirements to convert its transit fleet to zero-emission buses. These efforts will be heavily publicized, setting an example for the community and thereby increasing awareness of the benefits of public transit. This will be leveraged in

the County's marketing program to increase ridership and attract many new bus riders to the services, which will in turn reduce vehicle emissions countywide.

City of Chowchilla Transit Electrification and Modernization - The City of Chowchilla's projects are crucial to help the City and the Madera County region reach California's goal of reducing carbon emissions by 2030. The City has set a clear objective to modernize and improve its transportation system. The City of Chowchilla is requesting \$810,725 in TIRCP funding and \$895,350 in ZETCP funding for a total of \$1,706,075 to improve its transportation system by upgrading the fare collection system and purchasing two electric buses along with the required infrastructure. This funding will help the City of Chowchilla meet the State's requirement to transition the fleet to zero-emission buses. The location of the charging infrastructure will be coordinated with the County of Madera and any other relevant transit service providers to increase accessibility to transit-dependent riders throughout the region. The City of Chowchilla is designated as low-income as defined by AB 1550. Updating the ability for fare payment via mobile/contactless options on-board will modernize the transit services provided in Chowchilla, improving the transit rider experience, and increasing service accessibility to priority-populations.

City of Madera Transit Fleet Electrification - The City of Madera is requesting \$500,000 in ZETCP funds for the future purchase of electric vehicles and required charging stations. This funding will aid in transitioning the City's fleet to zero-emission buses as required by the State. The entire City of Madera and the surrounding area is in the CalEnviroScreen 4.0 Top 25% Disadvantaged Communities category. Providing public transportation with zero-emission buses in the Madera region will reduce greenhouse gas emissions and as a result will greatly improve the air quality and the health of the most vulnerable residents.